trusted media outlets, they began to fuel the fire, encouraging more migrants to take to the streets. An expert on Migration Studies later noted,

> The mainstream political opposition failed to make any worthwhile intervention not because it was ignorant of the existence of migrant workers, but because they could not think beyond conventional trade unionism and institutionalised routine politics. Failing to notice the impending crisis, the opposition forgot that the migrant question was a 'social' question.[10]

The Supreme Court intervened on 1 April. A Bench comprising Chief Justice S.A. Bobde and L. Nageswara Rao noted in a report on a petition concerning relief for stranded migrant workers that:

> The migration of large number of labourers working in the cities was triggered by panic created by fake news that the lockdown would continue for more than three months. Such panic driven migration has caused untold suffering to those who believed and acted on such news. In fact, some have lost their lives in the process. It is therefore not possible for us to overlook this menace of fake news either by electronic, print or social media. We do not want to interfere with the free discussion about the pandemic, but direct the media to refer to and publish the official version about coronavirus-related developments.

Invoking the 2005 Disaster Management Act, the court noted that it provides for punishment of up to one year or a fine for a person, 'who makes or circulates a false alarm warning regarding a disaster or its severity or magnitude, leading to panic'.[11]

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2 APRIL 2020

INDIA | 2,279 ACTIVE CASES | 73 DEATHS

WORLD | 8,44,303 ACTIVE CASES | 57,332 DEATHS

Since the beginning of last month, NITI Aayog members and experts from the technology industry, led by the National Informatics Centre (NIC), had been meeting extensively to perfect a contact tracing app. With the limited